

It works like this: you watch TV with your kids but turn the sound down when the ads come on. As they're watching an ad in silence, ask them three questions:

1. What is this ad flogging?
2. What are the tricks the ad's using to flog it? (Does the burger really look like that in real life?)
3. Do you really *need* it, or is it just something you might want?

If you're doing it right, they'll soon start to poke fun at the programs themselves. And the more subtle the branding becomes (read: 'integrated content'), the more kids need to be aware and cynical. So encourage them to call out product placement in reality shows like *MKR* and *The Block*. ('They're going to Mitre 10 again, Dad.')

Now you've had some fun subverting the marketing brainwashing, it's time to reverse it altogether . . . using your kids' own stuff.

In fact, we're going to use that stuff as the basis for your next Money Meal—the Family Treasure Hunt.

But first, let me answer some of your questions . . .

Everything you wanted to know about kids and 'stuff' in one and a bit pages

My kid wants to spend their Splurge Jar pocket money on crap . . . should I let them?

Yes you should, within limits (no weapons of mass destruction, of course).

You actually want them to make mistakes; that's how they'll learn. Better to blow all their money buying a toy car at age 7 so they don't make the mistake of leasing an Audi at age 27.